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CYBERSECURITY TALENT AVAILABILITY REPORT

Where Cybersecurity Talent Is
Available, Scarce, and
Difficult to Hire

A practical view of cybersecurity talent supply, skill scarcity, hiring competition, and sourcing opportunities.



TALENT
SUPPLY



SKILL
SCARCITY



HIRING
COMPETITION



LOCATION
INSIGHTS



SALARY
PRESSURE



TIME TO
HIRE



SOURCING
OPPORTUNITIES



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CYBERSECURITY TALENT AVAILABILITY REPORT

Where Cybersecurity Talent Is Available, Scarce, and Difficult to Hire

A practical view of cybersecurity talent supply, skill scarcity, hiring competition, and sourcing opportunities across 13 major cybersecurity roles.

About This Report

This report is designed for hiring managers, recruiters, HR leaders, and security executives who need a grounded, role-by-role view of the cybersecurity talent market. It covers talent supply, skill scarcity, location differences, hiring difficulty, salary pressure, and sourcing opportunities.

All availability ratings, salary benchmarks, and hiring timelines are illustrative planning estimates. Organizations should validate all figures against current market data for their specific location, industry, and compensation structure.

Report Details

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Roles Covered: 13 Cybersecurity Roles

Audience: Hiring Managers, Recruiters, HR Leaders, Security Executives

Classification: Workforce Planning Reference

 TEAMUP CONSULTANTS

2025 EDITION

WORKFORCE INTELLIG

Why Cybersecurity Talent Is Difficult to Hire

The cybersecurity talent market is defined by structural imbalances: demand grows faster than the pipeline can supply, and the most critical roles require years of hands-on experience that cannot be easily replicated through training alone. Organizations that approach cybersecurity hiring without a tailored strategy consistently face longer timelines, higher costs, and weaker outcomes.

Core Market Pressures

- Rapid growth in security roles outpaces talent pipeline development
- High barrier to entry requires certifications, experience, or specialized training
- Intense competition from large tech companies and well-funded startups
- Passive candidates are heavily recruited and difficult to engage
- Salary expectations rising faster than many organizations can match
- Geographic concentration of talent in major tech hubs creates regional scarcity

Roles with Greatest Hiring Pressure

- **Cloud Security Engineers** — extreme scarcity, 20–40% salary premium
- **Detection Engineers** — specialized, very limited supply
- **Security Architects** — senior-level scarcity, 16+ week timelines
- **Incident Response Analysts** — high demand, moderate supply
- **SOC Analysts** — high volume demand, entry-level quality bottleneck

Most In-Demand Skills

- Cloud security (AWS, Azure, GCP)
- Incident response and threat hunting
- Security automation and scripting
- Identity and access management (IAM)
- Detection engineering and SIEM expertise
- Application security and secure coding

Location & Work Model Impact

- Remote-first roles attract **3–5x more** qualified candidates
- Tier-1 cities (Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Delhi NCR) have concentrated talent but high competition
- Tier-2 cities offer emerging talent pools with **growth potential**
- International hiring expands the pool but requires visa sponsorship and timezone management

📌 **Key Insight:** Talent availability varies significantly by role, seniority, location, industry, salary range, and work model. Organizations must tailor sourcing strategies to each role's specific market conditions.

How to Read This Report

This report uses consistent terminology and a standardized availability scale across all role assessments. Understanding these definitions ensures you can accurately interpret findings and apply them to your organization's hiring context.

Key Terminology

Talent Supply

The number of qualified candidates available in the market for a specific role.

Talent Scarcity

How difficult it is to find candidates with the required skills and experience level.

Hiring Competition

The intensity of competition from other employers for the same talent pool.

Candidate Availability

Whether candidates are actively job-seeking (active) or require recruitment outreach (passive).

Salary Pressure

How much salary expectations exceed typical budget allocations in the market.

Market Maturity

Whether the role is established (mature) or emerging (developing) in the market.

Availability Scale

Used consistently throughout this report to assess each role's talent market conditions:

High Availability

Candidates readily available; moderate competition; standard hiring timeline (2–4 weeks).

Moderate Availability

Candidates available with targeted sourcing; competitive market; 4–8 week timeline.

Limited Availability

Few qualified candidates; significant competition; 8– premium compensation required.

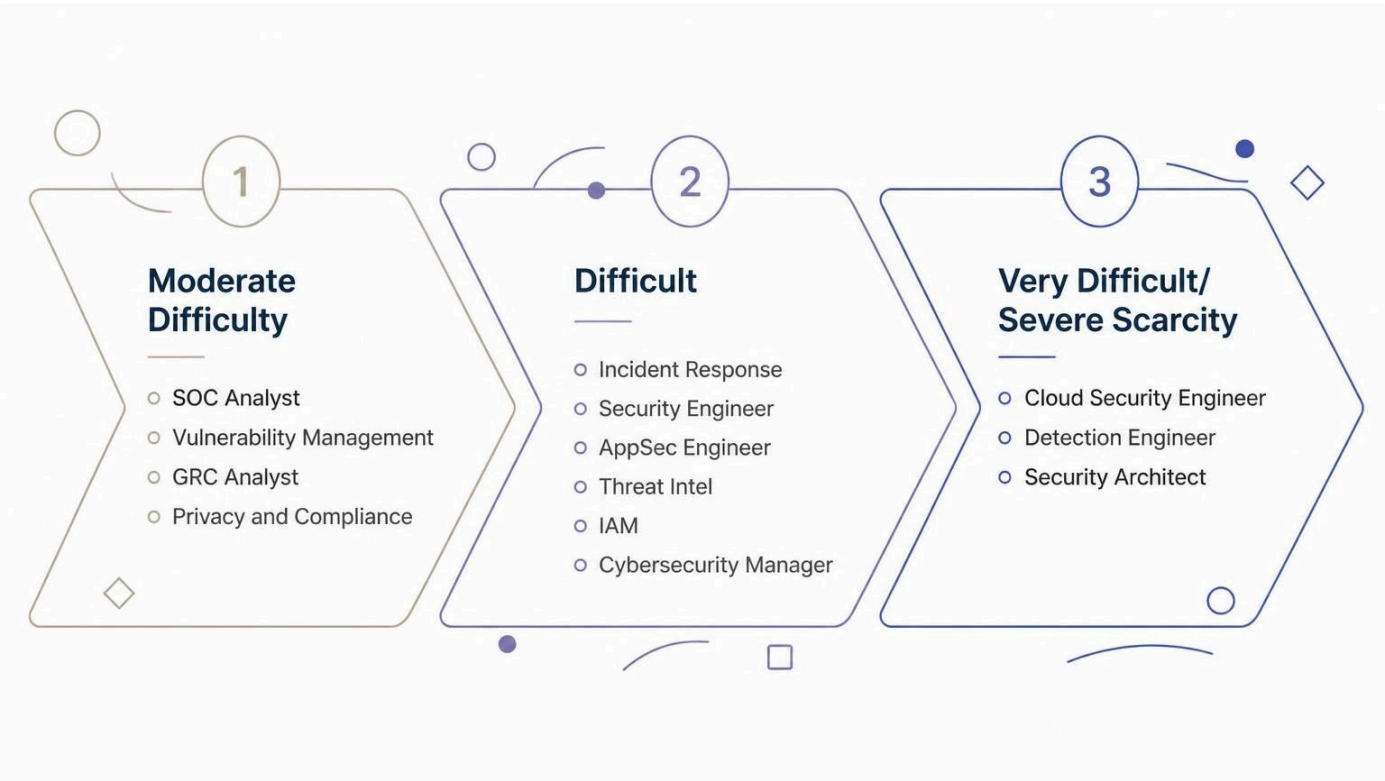
Severe Scarcity

Very few candidates; intense competition; 12+ week timeline; significant salary premium required.

Cybersecurity Role Availability Matrix

The table below summarizes availability and hiring difficulty across all 13 roles covered in this report. Ratings reflect market analysis and should be validated against your specific location, industry, and salary range.

Role	Seniority	Availability	Hiring Difficulty
SOC Analyst	Entry to Mid	Moderate	Moderate
Vulnerability Management Analyst	Entry to Mid	Moderate	Moderate
GRC Analyst	Entry to Mid	Moderate	Moderate
Privacy & Compliance Analyst	Entry to Mid	Moderate	Moderate
Incident Response Analyst	Mid to Senior	Limited	Difficult
Security Engineer	Mid to Senior	Limited	Difficult
Application Security Engineer	Mid to Senior	Limited	Difficult
Threat Intelligence Analyst	Mid to Senior	Limited	Difficult
IAM Specialist	Mid to Senior	Limited	Difficult
Cybersecurity Manager	Leadership	Limited	Difficult
Cloud Security Engineer	Mid to Senior	Severe Scarcity	Very Difficult
Detection Engineer	Mid to Senior	Severe Scarcity	Very Difficult
Security Architect	Senior to Leadership	Severe Scarcity	Very Difficult



Role Details: Skills, Certifications & Sourcing Strategies

The following profiles highlight common skills, certifications, sourcing channels, and primary hiring challenges for four of the most frequently recruited cybersecurity roles. These profiles support job description development, sourcing strategy design, and interview planning.

 SOC Analyst Common Skills: SIEM tools (Splunk, ELK), log analysis, alert triage, incident documentation, networking basics Certifications: CompTIA Security+, CEH, GIAC Security Essentials (GSEC) Sourcing: Universities, bootcamps, employee referrals, specialist recruiters Main Challenge: High entry-level volume but quality varies; retention difficult due to shift work and analyst burnout	 Incident Response Analyst Common Skills: Forensics, malware analysis, threat hunting, incident documentation, communication under pressure Certifications: GCIH (Incident Handler), GCFE (Forensic Examiner) Sourcing: Specialist recruiters, internal promotion from SOC, professional networks Main Challenge: Requires 3–5 years SOC experience; limited passive candidate pool; high salary expectations
 Cloud Security Engineer Common Skills: AWS/Azure/GCP security, infrastructure-as-code, container security, cloud architecture Certifications: AWS Certified Security Specialty, Azure Security Engineer Associate, Kubernetes Security Sourcing: Specialist recruiters, cloud communities, tech conferences, direct passive outreach Main Challenge: Extreme scarcity; heavily recruited; 20–40% salary premium typical; 12+ week timeline	 Detection Engineer Common Skills: SIEM/EDR platforms, threat hunting, detection rule development, scripting (Python, PowerShell) Certifications: Certified Intrusion Analyst (GCERT) Sourcing: Specialist recruiters, security conferences, direct passive candidate outreach Main Challenge: Highly specialized; very few candidates; intense competition; significant salary premium required

Entry-Level Cybersecurity Talent: Availability & Assessment

Entry-level talent represents the most accessible pipeline for cybersecurity teams, but quality varies widely across candidates. Effective assessment and structured onboarding are essential to convert potential into performance.

Available Skills

- Networking fundamentals (TCP/IP, DNS, HTTP)
- Operating system basics (Windows, Linux)
- Log analysis and SIEM tool navigation
- Alert triage and incident documentation
- Vulnerability scanning tools (Nessus, OpenVAS)
- Basic scripting (Python, PowerShell)
- Compliance frameworks (NIST, ISO 27001 overview)

Common Training Routes

- University cybersecurity programs (4-year degrees)
- Bootcamps (3–6 months, intensive)
- CompTIA Security+ certification programs
- Vendor training (Splunk, Palo Alto, Microsoft)
- Internship programs at large tech companies
- Self-study with lab environments (TryHackMe, HackTheBox)

Typical Skill Gaps

- Limited hands-on incident response experience
- Weak communication and documentation skills
- Insufficient understanding of business context
- Limited exposure to real-world attack scenarios
- Gaps in specific tool expertise (SIEM, EDR, firewalls)

How to Assess Entry-Level Potential

01

Technical Assessment

Basic networking, OS, and scripting questions covering foundational knowledge

02

Lab Exercise

Triage alerts in a SIEM s environment to evaluate hands-on capability

03

Communication Test

ate to explain a security concept to a non-technical person

04

Motivation Assessment

Why cybersecurity? Which specific area interests them most and why?

05

Learning Ability

Have they completed certifications or bootcamps? Can they explain what they learned?

Mid-Level Cybersecurity Talent: Competition & Retention

Mid-level professionals (2–5 years of experience) represent the most contested segment of the cybersecurity market. They are experienced enough to contribute immediately but junior enough to remain within most budget ranges — making them attractive to a wide range of employers simultaneously.

Common Experience Profile

- 2–5 years in security operations, engineering, or compliance roles
- Hands-on experience with 2–3 major security tools (SIEM, EDR, firewall, IDS/IPS)
- Led or participated in incident response activities
- Managed security projects or initiatives
- Mentored junior team members
- Contributed to security process improvements

Common Tools & Platforms

- **SIEM:** Splunk, ELK Stack, ArcSight, Sumo Logic
- **EDR:** CrowdStrike, Microsoft Defender, SentinelOne
- **Cloud:** AWS, Azure, or GCP (at least one platform)
- **Vulnerability Mgmt:** Qualys, Tenable, Rapid7
- **Firewalls:** Palo Alto, Fortinet, Cisco
- **Scripting:** Python, PowerShell, Bash

Hiring Competition Factors

- High competition from large enterprises and well-funded startups
- Passive candidates heavily recruited — multiple offers are typical
- Salary expectations **30–50% above entry-level** (illustrative estimate)
- Candidates often have 2–3 competing offers simultaneously
- Notice periods typically 2–4 weeks

Retention Risk Factors

- **High mobility:** Mid-level candidates frequently change roles for a 15–25% salary increase
- **Burnout risk:** On-call responsibilities and incident pressure drive departures
- **Career clarity:** Candidates want a clear path to senior or specialized roles
- **Skill development:** Candidates seek opportunities to learn new tools and



Retention Alert: Mid-level cybersecurity professionals are the most likely to leave within 18 months if career growth, compensation, and learning opportunities are not clearly defined at the time of hire. Proactively establish a development plan during onboarding.

Senior & Leadership-Level Talent: Scarcity & Executive Hiring

Senior and leadership-level cybersecurity professionals represent the most critical and most scarce segment of the market. Their combination of deep technical expertise, strategic thinking, and communication ability makes them exceptionally difficult to replace – and exceptionally difficult to recruit.

Senior-Level: What Employers Expect

- 5–10+ years of security experience across multiple domains
- Deep expertise in 1–2 specialized areas
- Demonstrated ability to lead projects and mentor teams
- Strategic thinking: Can connect security decisions to business outcomes
- Executive communication: Can explain complex security to non-technical stakeholders
- Vendor and tool expertise: Can evaluate, implement, and optimize platforms

Senior-Level: Scarcity Factors

- Only **15–20%** of the cybersecurity workforce reaches senior level (illustrative)
- Senior candidates typically stay **4–6 years** in roles – low churn
- **80%+** of senior candidates are not actively job-seeking (illustrative)
- Senior talent concentrated in major tech hubs
- Cloud security architects and detection leaders are extremely rare

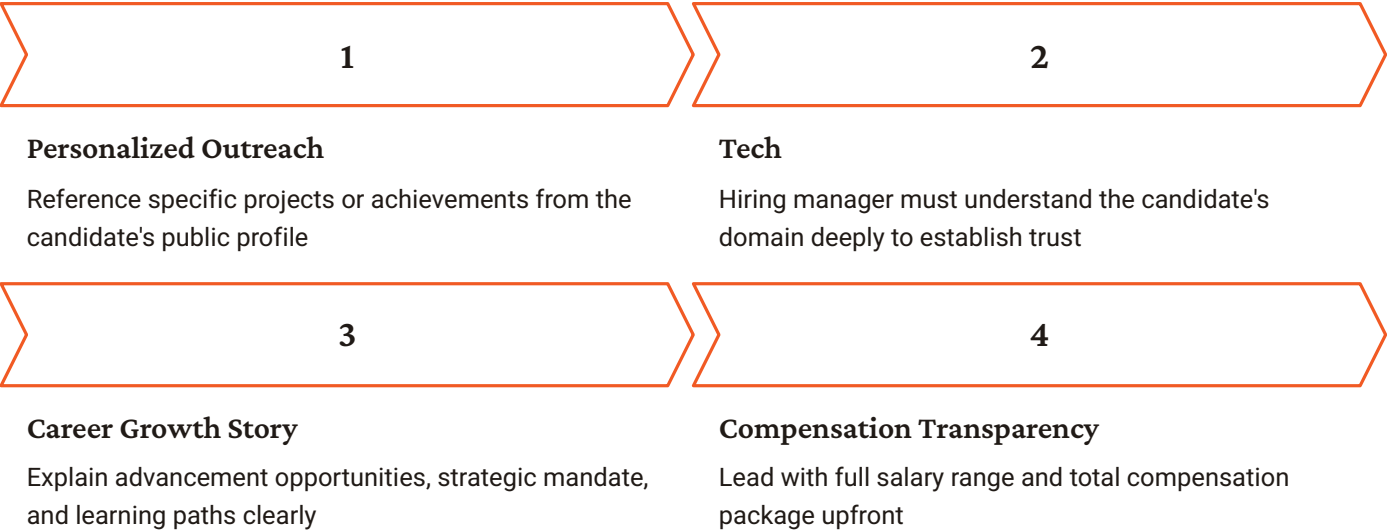
Leadership-Level: Strategic Responsibilities

- Security strategy and roadmap development
- Budget planning and resource allocation
- Risk assessment and executive reporting
- Vendor management and tool evaluation
- Team building and talent development
- Board and executive communication
- Regulatory compliance and audit management

Executive Hiring Considerations

- **Scarcity:** Severe – very few qualified candidates available
- **Timeline:** 16–24 weeks typical; executive search firms often required
- **Compensation:** Equity, bonus, and benefits packages are critical differentiators
- **Sourcing:** Executive recruiters, board networks, industry conferences
- **Retention:** Clear strategic mandate and board support are essential

Passive Candidate Outreach Strategy for Senior Roles



Most In-Demand Technical Skills: Foundations & Operations

Understanding which skills drive hiring difficulty — and how to assess them — allows organizations to write better job descriptions, design more effective interviews, and make faster, higher-quality hiring decisions. This section covers foundational and operational technical skills.

SIEM — Security Information & Event Management

Demand Level: High (consistent, ongoing)

Why Employers Need It: Core capability for threat detection, compliance reporting, and incident investigation across the organization.

Candidate Demonstration: Hands-on experience with Splunk, ELK, ArcSight, or Sumo Logic; ability to write queries and build dashboards.

Assessment Approach: Practical exercise — write a query to detect suspicious login patterns; explain dashboard design choices.

EDR — Endpoint Detection & Response

Demand Level: High (rapidly growing)

Why Employers Need It: Essential for detecting and responding to endpoint threats; replacing traditional antivirus in most mature security programs.

Candidate Demonstration: Experience with CrowdStrike, Microsoft Defender, SentinelOne, or Cortex XDR; incident response using EDR data.

Assessment Approach: Case study — analyze EDR alerts and recommend response actions; explain detection logic and escalation criteria.

Networking & Network Security

Demand Level: High (foundational skill)

Why Employers Need It: Essential for understanding traffic flows, firewalls, IDS/IPS, and network segmentation in all security roles.

Candidate Demonstration: Understanding of TCP/IP, DNS, HTTP/HTTPS, VPN, firewalls; experience with network monitoring tools.

Assessment Approach: Technical questions — explain a network segmentation strategy; troubleshoot a connectivity issue under time pressure.

Identity & Access Management (IAM)

Demand Level: High (growing)

Why Employers Need It: Critical for zero-trust architecture, cloud security, and compliance; foundational to modern security programs.

Candidate Demonstration: Experience with Active Directory, Azure AD, Okta, or other IAM platforms; understanding of authentication and authorization.

Assessment Approach: Design exercise — plan an IAM strategy for a hybrid cloud environment; explain MFA and conditional access policies.

Most In-Demand Technical Skills: Advanced & Specialized

The following skills represent the highest-pressure areas of the cybersecurity talent market. Candidates with these capabilities are scarce, heavily recruited, and command significant salary premiums. Organizations hiring for these skills must adopt a proactive, personalized sourcing approach.

Cloud Security — AWS, Azure, GCP

Demand: **Very High (extreme scarcity)**

Why Needed: Critical as organizations migrate to cloud; requires specialized cloud-native security knowledge that traditional security engineers often lack.

Candidate Demonstration: Cloud certifications (AWS Security Specialty, Azure Security Engineer); hands-on cloud infrastructure experience.

Assessment: Architecture exercise — design secure cloud infrastructure covering identity, network, and data protection controls.

Vulnerability Management

Demand:

Why Needed: Core capability for risk management and compliance; required by most security frameworks including NIST, ISO 27001, and SOC 2.

Candidate Demonstration: Experience with Qualys, Tenable, Rapid7, or similar tools; understanding of vulnerability prioritization and remediation workflows.

Assessment: Case study — prioritize a vulnerability list; explain remediation strategy and risk acceptance rationale.

Incident Response & Threat Hunting

Demand: **Very High (limited supply)**

Why Needed: Critical capability for detecting and responding to breaches; increasingly required by regulations and cyber insurance requirements.

Candidate Demonstration: Hands-on incident response experience; threat hunting methodology; forensics and malware analysis skills.

Assessment: Incident simulation — analyze logs and artifacts; recommend containment and eradication steps.

Application Security & Secure Coding

Demand:

Why Needed: Critical for preventing application vulnerabilities; increasingly required as development teams adopt DevSecOps practices.

Candidate Demonstration: Code review experience; OWASP Top 10 knowledge; experience with SAST/DAST tools; secure coding practices.

Assessment: Code review exercise — identify vulnerabilities in sample code; recommend secure alternatives and explain the risk.

Threat Detection & SIEM Rule Development

Demand: **Very High (severe scarcity)**

Why Needed: Essential for proactive threat detection; requires deep understanding of attack techniques, adversary behavior, and detection platforms.

Candidate Demonstration: Detection engineering experience; MITRE ATT&CK framework knowledge; ability to write and tune detection rules.

Assessment: Technical exercise — write detection rules for a specific attack scenario; explain detection logic and tuning rationale.

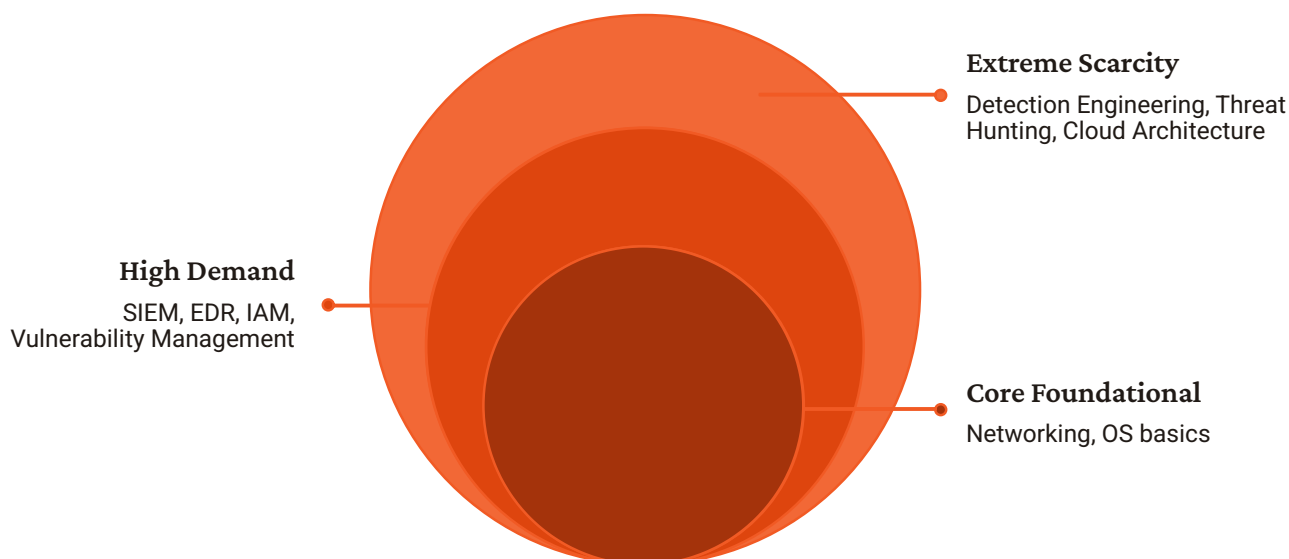
Security Automation & Scripting

Demand:

Why Needed: Essential for scaling security operations; reduces manual work and improves response time across detection, response, and reporting workflows.

Candidate Demonstration: Python, PowerShell, or Bash scripting; experience with automation frameworks; understanding of APIs and integrations.

Assessment: Coding exercise — write a script to automate a security task; explain design decisions and error handling approach.



This demand spectrum illustrates how skills translate directly into sourcing complexity and compensation pressure. Organizations hiring for extreme-scarcity skills must adopt executive-level sourcing strategies regardless of seniority level.

Key Takeaways & Workforce Planning Guidance

Cybersecurity hiring success requires a tailored, role-specific approach. There is no single strategy that works across all roles, seniority levels, and geographies. The following frameworks consolidate the report's findings into actionable guidance for hiring managers, recruiters, and HR leaders.

Strategic Principles for Cybersecurity Hiring

1 Tailor Strategy to Each Role

SOC Analyst hiring requires volume pipeline management. Cloud Security Engineer hiring requires executive-level passive candidate outreach. Never use the same approach for both.

2 Lead with Compensation Transparency

Cybersecurity candidates — especially at mid and senior levels — have multiple options. Publishing salary ranges and leading with total compensation in outreach significantly improves response rates.

3 Prioritize Remote or Hybrid Flexibility

Remote-first roles attract measurably larger and more qualified candidate pools. For scarce roles, remote flexibility is not optional — it is a sourcing strategy.

4 Build Internal Pipelines

Promote SOC Analysts into Incident Response. Develop Detection Engineering skills internally. Internal mobility reduces scarcity pressure for the hardest-to-fill roles.

Workforce Planning Checklist

Use the following checklist to validate your hiring readiness before launching a cybersecurity search:

- ☐ Confirm role seniority level and primary skill requirements
- ☐ Identify the role's availability rating using the matrix in this report
- ☐ Validate salary range against current market data for your location
- ☐ Define work model (remote, hybrid, or on-site) and assess its impact on candidate pool
- ☐ Confirm interview process: number of stages, technical assessment format, timeline
- ☐ Assign a dedicated sourcing resource (internal recruiter or specialist agency)
- ☐ Plan passive candidate outreach strategy for Limited or Severe Scarcity roles
- ☐ Establish a hiring timeline with milestones and escalation triggers
- ☐ Prepare a retention plan: career growth, learning budget, compensation review cycle
- ☐ Schedule a post-hire 90-day check-in to validate role fit and engagement

Important Disclaimers

All salary benchmarks, availability ratings, hiring timelines, and candidate supply estimates in this report are **illustrative planning estimates**. They are intended to guide thinking and planning, not to replace real-time market data. Organizations should validate all figures against current market intelligence for their specific location, industry, compensation structure, and seniority requirements.

Candidate supply and competition levels change monthly. All ratings in this report should be reviewed at least quarterly against live market conditions.

About TeamUp Consultants

TeamUp Consultants is a specialist workforce talent advisory firm focused on technology and cybersecurity hiring. We help organizations build hiring strategies grounded in real market data, role-specific sourcing approaches, and long-term workforce planning.

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